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against terror". His term of office as President pressure expires in November, but there are constitutional and political obstacles to his seeking re-election which he has already announced he will do. The threat of street unrest looms large with the expected return of exiled former prime minister Nawaz Sharif on September 10. The current pro-Musharraf Parliament's tenure also expires in November and there is no clarity about what kind of assemblies fresh elections will throw up. Finally, there is immense pressure—domestic and international—on the General to hang up his army uniform. But he realises that may reduce him to a figurehead without the army's clout at his command.

One can almost sense the tension in the air as the critical dates get nearer. News channels and the newspapers are full of speculative stories about the possible permutations being considered by Musharraf's advisers as well as leaked intelligence assessments of the strength of the various parties. Hourly updates about "breakthroughs" and the conflicting statements of various politicians are considerably muddying up the atmosphere as well. Even as Sharif vows to return "to rid the country of dictatorship because my country needs me", news breaks about the Saudi Government allegedly asking Sharif not to return to Pakistan. But matters are still so fluid that no two people are able to agree on what the future holds in store. In Islamabad, still reeling under the aftermath of the polarising Lal Masjid showdown and a subsequent militant campaign of suicide bombings, the mood of anticipation about "something big about to happen" is so great that some are seriously asking the question whether Pakistan stands at a crossroad similar to Iran before the revolution in 1979.

For most observers, this is the beginning of the end for Musharraf. His aides have been engaged in desperate negotiations to hammer out some sort of a deal with former premier Benazir Bhutto that might stave off the challenges to his rule. In itself, the very fact

CORNERED: Musharraf is making desperate attempts to retain power

president and remain the army chief, but with his position considerably weakened he cannot be both. ★